

RIP PASSWORDS: SAY HELLO TO PASKEYS

Forget the constant struggle of remembering complex passwords and the frustration of resetting forgotten ones. Passkeys, a new wave of authentication technology, promise a more secure and convenient login experience for the future.

How Passkeys Work: Unlike traditional passwords, vulnerable to guessing and phishing attacks, passkeys rely on a system of cryptographic keys. Your device (phone or computer) securely stores a private key, while a public key is shared with websites and apps. Instead of manually entering a password, you use biometric authentication like your fingerprint, face scan, or PIN to unlock the private key on your device. This eliminates the need to remember complex passwords and reduces the risk of them being stolen.

The FIDO Alliance, a collaboration of tech giants like Apple, Google, and Microsoft, is at the forefront of developing and implementing passkeys. Apple has already integrated them into iOS 16 and macOS Ventura, allowing users to sign in with their iPhones or Macs. With other major companies expected to follow suit, cross-platform compatibility is being built in. Imagine using your phone to securely log in to a website on your laptop and vice versa.

While the potential for a password-less future is undeniable, complete eradication might not happen



overnight. Widespread adoption across websites and apps will require time, and legacy systems might still necessitate passwords. Additionally, secure backup mechanisms for passkeys are still under development, meaning losing your device or encountering technical issues could lead to access problems.

Despite these challenges, passkeys represent a significant leap forward in online security. Eliminating passwords removes a major vulnerability exploited by hackers, while offering a vastly improved user experience.

Setting Up MFA

- **Choose Your MFA Method:** Decide which form of MFA suits you best. Authenticator apps are generally more secure than SMS codes, as they are less susceptible to interception.
- **Enable MFA on Your Accounts:** Most online services offer MFA options in their security settings. Follow the prompts to add an extra layer of protection.
- **Backup Your Access:** Ensure you have backup access methods in case you lose your primary MFA device. Many services offer backup codes or alternative verification methods.

Recognising and Avoiding Phishing Attacks

Phishing attacks are deceitful attempts to steal sensitive information by impersonating legitimate sources. Recognizing these attempts is critical to your online safety.

Phishing communications often urge immediate action, contain spelling or grammatical errors, and use generic greet-

ings. URLs might look suspicious, with slight deviations from the legitimate address intended to deceive the recipient.

Best Practices for Avoiding Phishing

- **Verify the Sender:** Hover over email addresses and links to see the actual URL or address. If in doubt, contact the supposed sender through a verified method.
- **Do Not Click on Unknown Links:** Avoid clicking on links or downloading attachments from unknown or unsolicited emails.
- **Use Security Software:** Employ software that provides email scanning and web protection to block phishing attempts.

Safe Browsing Practices

Navigating the internet safely involves understanding the risks and employing strategies to mitigate them.

Secure Web Browsing

Always ensure your connection to websites is secure, indicated by "HTTPS" rather than just "HTTP" in the URL. This encryp-